10 POINTS · SCORE YOURSELF IN 5 MINUTES

THE 10/10 PROFILE GUIDE

A scored audit of your LinkedIn profile for founders and B2B execs. Ten checks, one point each, with the rule, a template and a before and after for every one.

WHY BOTHER

Everyone you message checks your profile before they reply, whether it's an investor, a candidate or the buyer you cold DMed on Monday. They click your name, look for a few seconds and decide if you're worth an answer.

Most founder profiles lose that moment: the headline says "Co-founder", the banner is LinkedIn's grey default or a city skyline, and nothing on the page explains what the company does.

I'm a partner at RallyUp, where we write LinkedIn for B2B founders and executives. We've generated 21.3M+ impressions for them, and we run this audit before we post a word for anyone.

> **The honest limit.** These ten checks are my judgement from fixing founder profiles, not a LinkedIn ranking factor. A 10/10 profile won't get you reach on its own; what it does is make sure the people who land on it understand what you do, believe you and know what to do next.

HOW TO SCORE

Open your profile in a private window so you see what a stranger sees, then go down the table giving yourself 1 for a pass and 0 for a miss. There are no half points: if you have to argue for it, it's a 0.

#	ELEMENT	YOU PASS IF	SCORE
01	**Photo**	Bright, close and recent, and clearly you	__ / 1
02	**Banner message**	Says who it's for and what you do, read in one glance	__ / 1
03	**Banner proof**	One piece of proof: a result, logos or a backer	__ / 1
04	**Banner call to action**	One clear next step	__ / 1
05	**Headline: who you help**	A stranger can say who you help and with what	__ / 1
06	**Headline: proof**	A number, a name or a backer instead of adjectives	__ / 1
07	**About: opening lines**	The lines before "see more" say problem, fix and proof	__ / 1
08	**Featured section**	One to three items, the first one is what you want clicked	__ / 1
09	**Experience**	Your current role lists results instead of duties	__ / 1
10	**How to work with you**	A stranger knows exactly what to do next	__ / 1

0 to 4: people are deciding not to reply, so do the 30 minute fix today. **5 to 7:** you have the basics but the proof is missing. **8 to 9:** fix the one or two misses this week. **10:** stop editing and go send the messages.

Every name, company and number in the examples below is made up.

THE 10 CHECKS

01 · PHOTO

A face people recognise when they meet you

FIX TIME: 4 MINUTES · WHERE: PROFILE PHOTO

Your photo sits next to every message, comment and post you write, and it's what people check your face against when the call starts.

> **The rule.** Shoulders up, face filling most of the circle, in good light, taken in the last two years. Use a plain or soft background, and aim for you on a good day rather than a passport photo.

> **Fails:** a dark photo, a photo cropped out of a group, sunglasses, a logo, a wedding, the grey silhouette, a picture from ten years ago.

HOW TO TAKE IT

Face a window in daylight with your phone at eye level and a plain wall behind you. Take 20 and keep the one where you look easiest to talk to.

BEFORE

Maya, co-founder of Tallyhouse: a dim photo from a conference, cropped from a group, her face a small part of the frame.

AFTER

Maya by a window, shoulders up, plain wall, smiling. Bright enough to recognise at thumbnail size.

02 · BANNER MESSAGE

Who it's for, in one glance

FIX TIME: 8 MINUTES, WITH THE NEXT TWO · WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO

The banner is the biggest space on your profile, a free billboard above your name, and most founders leave it grey. Use it to say what you do and who it's for.

> **The rule.** One line, big enough to read on a phone; if someone has to read it twice, it's carrying too much. Keep text away from the bottom left, where your photo covers it. LinkedIn recommends 1584 × 396 pixels.

> **Fails:** LinkedIn's default grey banner, a stock photo, a skyline, a quote, or a banner so packed with logos, taglines and icons that you read it twice.

TEMPLATE

```
[Outcome] for [who].
e.g. "[Get paid faster] for [construction finance teams]."
```

BEFORE

A stock photo of a glass office tower with "Innovate. Disrupt. Grow." across it.

AFTER

"Supplier invoices matched in minutes, for construction finance teams."

03 · BANNER PROOF

One reason to believe you

WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO, UNDER THE MESSAGE

A claim with nothing behind it reads like an ad, and one piece of proof is usually enough to make people take it seriously.

> **The rule.** Pick one: a client result, three to five customer logos, or borrowed trust, like the investors who backed you or the companies your team came from. Then leave the other two out.

> **Fails:** no proof at all, or a wall of fifteen logos nobody can read at thumbnail size.

PICK ONE

```
[Result] for [type of customer]
Trusted by [logo] [logo] [logo]
Backed by [investor] and [investor]
```

BEFORE

Just the message, with nothing under it.

AFTER

"Backed by Wrenfield Capital" in small type under the message, with three customer logos.

04 · BANNER CALL TO ACTION

Tell them what to do next

WHERE: BACKGROUND PHOTO, RIGHT HAND SIDE

Someone who likes what they see needs somewhere to go, and if you don't point them there, they drift back to their feed.

> **The rule.** Write one action as an instruction, with a short address they can type: join the waitlist, book a demo or read the newsletter. Pick a single one.

> **Fails:** no call to action, or three competing ones, or a long tracking link nobody will type.

TEMPLATE

```
[Verb] [the thing] at [short address]
e.g. "Join the waitlist at [company].com"
```

BEFORE

No next step anywhere on the banner.

AFTER

"Book a 15 minute demo at tallyhouse.com" on the right, away from the photo.

05 · HEADLINE: WHO YOU HELP

What you do, and for who

FIX TIME: 8 MINUTES, WITH THE NEXT ONE · WHERE: HEADLINE

Your headline follows you into comments, search results and every DM preview, and for most people it's the only line of your profile they'll ever read.

> **The rule.** Someone who has never heard of your company should be able to say who you help and with what, after reading it once.

> **Fails:** "Co-founder", "Co-founder, CEO, we're hiring", "Building something new", or "Founder @ [company]" when nobody knows the company yet.

THREE FORMULAS

```
A. [Role] at [Company]: we help [who] [do what].
B. Helping [who] [outcome] | [Role], [Company]
C. [Company] = [what it is] for [who] | [Role]
```

BEFORE

Co-founder, CEO at Tallyhouse. We're hiring!

AFTER

CEO at Tallyhouse: we help construction finance teams match supplier invoices in minutes.

06 · HEADLINE: PROOF

A number beats an adjective

WHERE: END OF THE HEADLINE

Anyone can type "passionate", "visionary" or "serial entrepreneur", whereas a number, a name or a backer is something you had to earn.

> **The rule.** Add one piece of proof to the end of the headline. It can be the same proof as the banner or a different one.

> **Fails:** no proof, or proof made of adjectives.

ADD ONE

```
| [Result] for [N] [customers]
| Backed by [investor]
| Ex-[company people know], [role]
```

BEFORE

Passionate sales leader | Visionary | Builder

AFTER

VP Sales at Mossbank Analytics: we help retailers forecast stock. | Built the first sales team at Puddlejump, 0 to 40 reps

07 · ABOUT: OPENING LINES

Write for the lines before "see more"

FIX TIME: 5 MINUTES · WHERE: ABOUT SECTION

LinkedIn cuts your About off after the opening lines, and most people never click "see more", so those first lines have to carry it.

> **The rule.** Open with the problem your buyer has, follow with what you do about it, then add proof. Your life story can go further down, if it goes in at all.

> **Fails:** "I'm a passionate leader with 15 years of experience", a story that starts in your childhood, or your company homepage pasted in.

TEMPLATE

```
[Who] [lose time or money on this problem].
At [Company], we [fix it by doing what].
[Proof: result, customers or backer].
[What to do next: where to find you].
```

BEFORE

I'm a results-driven founder passionate about the future of finance. With a background in...

AFTER

Construction finance teams spend days matching supplier invoices by hand. Tallyhouse does it in minutes. 60 firms use it every month. Book a demo at tallyhouse.com.

08 · FEATURED SECTION

Pick what they click first

FIX TIME: 3 MINUTES · WHERE: FEATURED

Featured sits near the top of your profile, with pictures, so it draws more clicks than anything else on the page after your name. Most founders leave it empty or full of old reposts.

> **The rule.** One to three items. The first is the thing you most want a stranger to see: a demo, a case study, the waitlist, your best post.

> **Fails:** empty, six items, or a repost of a funding announcement from two years ago.

ORDER

```
1. [The action you want: demo, waitlist, newsletter]
2. [Proof: a case study or customer story]
3. [Your best post, the one that explains what you do]
```

BEFORE

Empty.

AFTER

1. Two minute demo video. 2. A customer story. 3. Maya's post on why she started Tallyhouse.

09 · EXPERIENCE

Proof, not a job description

FIX TIME: THIS WEEK, NOT TODAY · WHERE: EXPERIENCE

Buyers and investors who scroll this far want to know if you've done it before, and a list of duties can't tell them that.

> **The rule.** For your current role: one line on what the company does, then two or three results with a number in each. Older roles can be one line.

> **Fails:** "Responsible for managing", duties copied from a job ad, or a current role with no description at all.

TEMPLATE

```
[Company] [does what] for [who].
• [Result with a number]
• [Result with a number]
• [Who you work with or who backs you]
```

BEFORE

CEO. Responsible for strategy, fundraising and team leadership.

AFTER

Tallyhouse matches supplier invoices for construction finance teams. Grew from 0 to 60 customers in 18 months. Raised a seed round from Wrenfield Capital.

10 · HOW TO WORK WITH YOU

Make the next step obvious

FIX TIME: 2 MINUTES · WHERE: END OF ABOUT, PLUS ONE OTHER PLACE

By now they've read your profile and they're interested, which was the hard part, so don't make them work out how to buy, invest or apply.

> **The rule.** End your About with one clear next step, and repeat it in one other place: the banner, the first Featured item or your contact info. Use the same action everywhere.

> **Fails:** no next step, or "feel free to reach out", which asks the reader to do the thinking.

TEMPLATE

```
If you [are who you help] and [have the problem], [do this] at [address].
Or DM me "[keyword]" and I'll send you [the thing].
```

BEFORE

Feel free to reach out!

AFTER

If you run finance at a construction firm, book a 15 minute demo at tallyhouse.com.

FIX IT IN 30 MINUTES

Work in this order. Everyone sees the top of your profile and only a few reach the bottom, so fix what most people see first.

ORDER	FIX	TIME	CHECKS
1	**Headline.** Pick a formula, fill the brackets, add one proof point.	8 min	05, 06
2	**Banner.** A line, a proof point and an action. A free design tool and a blank 1584 × 396 canvas will do.	8 min	02, 03, 04
3	**About opening.** Problem, fix, proof, next step. Leave the rest for later.	5 min	07, 10
4	**Photo.** Window, eye level, plain wall. Retake it if it's dark.	4 min	01
5	**Featured.** Pin the one thing you want clicked first.	3 min	08
6	**Check the next step.** Same action in the About and one other place.	2 min	10
Later	**Experience.** Rewrite your current role as results this week.	20 min	09

The stranger test. When you're done, send your profile to one person outside your industry and ask two questions: what do I do, and who for? If they can't answer in one go, start again at the headline.

THE CHECKLIST

Print this page or keep it open next to your profile, and only tick a box when a stranger would agree.

- [ ] **01 Photo.** Bright, close, recent, plain background, clearly me.
- [ ] **02 Banner message.** One line that says what I do and who for. Readable on a phone in one glance.
- [ ] **03 Banner proof.** One kind of proof: a result, three to five logos, or a backer.
- [ ] **04 Banner call to action.** One action with a short address.
- [ ] **05 Headline: who I help.** A stranger can say who I help and with what.
- [ ] **06 Headline: proof.** A number, a name or a backer. No adjectives doing the work.
- [ ] **07 About opening.** Problem, fix, proof, all before "see more".
- [ ] **08 Featured.** One to three items, the first is the thing I want clicked.
- [ ] **09 Experience.** My current role shows what the company does and two or three results.
- [ ] **10 Next step.** The same clear action at the end of my About and in one other place.

My score	__ / 10

Some of last week's unanswered messages were judged on the old profile. A friendly nudge gives those people a second look at the new one.

Francisco Gost writes The Draft, a weekly letter on how top 1% startups crush organic marketing, at franciscogost.com

Partner at RallyUp. 21.3M+ impressions generated for B2B founders and execs.